

would be shrouded in quiet, lonely emptiness. I knew then that I could not live without him, no matter what the cost.

But I make no judgments. Who can say what that couple's motivation was? The two stepped outside to talk, and only the husband returned as Wesley and I were checking out.

Another \$7 for a nail clipping brought our total to \$92, which I paid through gritted teeth. Now I set aside a small amount regularly to cover Wesley's emergencies and pray that I never have to use it.

As rewarding as pet ownership is, it can also be heart-wrenching and expensive. Wesley doesn't know the trouble he can get into because of my negligence. Regular grooming and care can be time-consuming and inconvenient for us sometimes, but we need to make an unconditional commitment to our feathered and furred friends. Personally, I cannot put any price on the joy I experience just watching Wesley's funny antics or having him cuddle with me on the couch in cold weather. Although the cost is sometimes a big one to pay, the return is priceless.

Raptor Rehabilitation Underway in North Carolina

THE CAROLINA RAPTOR Center in Charlotte, North Carolina, treats nearly 500 injured or orphaned birds of prey each year. The center works closely with many general rehabilitators in both North and South Carolina.

Each year the center receives raptors that have accidentally been imprinted on humans instead of their own species, said executive director Patricia A. Marcum. "Imprinting occurs with all birds and animals when they are babies. It is what teaches them their species identity. Imprinting is especially strong among birds and occurs over a very short period. It is irreversible. Once a bird imprints on the image of the face caring for it, that becomes its species identity for life," she said.

"Sometimes we see birds that should have been released to the



PHOTO: JILL WILLIAMS

Raptors like this hawk should be left to live in the wild rather than be allowed to imprint on humans.

wild to fulfill their important role in helping to maintain nature's balance, but they have been kept too long in captivity," Marcum continued. "They become food dependent on humans, and it becomes very difficult, if not impossible, to release them without their still seeing humans as food sources and approaching them for food after release. Sometimes people kill these human-dependent birds because they think the birds are attacking them."

Marcum would like to encourage BIRD TALK readers to leave wild animals and birds in their natural environments. She believes that

humans interfere too much with nature, and "we have a terrible track record when we do."

Julio's Vacation by Willie Toth

JULIO IS A beautiful 28-year-old Tres Marias Amazon. He is known for his cantankerous airs, and he seems to pride himself on his fearful barks, which are much stronger than his bites.

After three unsuccessful years in a breeding program, Julio came back to live with me, my wife and a yellow naped Amazon, Logan the Lovable, whom we had purchased—